

Pregnancy - Itching - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1365 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- UAT-only assessment of itching in a confirmed current pregnancy, including recognition of possible intrahepatic cholestasis of pregnancy; not approved for real-patient or production use.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [YES_NO] Is the patient currently pregnant, and has the pregnancy been confirmed?
2. [OPEN_TEXT] How old is the patient and how many weeks pregnant are they?
3. [YES_NO] Can the patient speak privately and safely? If under 18, assess coercion, abuse, exploitation, and whether the accompanying adult may be unsafe under the Qatar safeguarding pathway approved for UAT.
4. [OPEN_TEXT] Where is the itching worst, is there a rash, is it worse at night, and how long has it lasted?
5. [YES_NO] Is there yellowing of the skin or eyes, dark urine, pale stools, or reduced or changed fetal movement?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Rash or Redness - Widespread

Is a widespread rash the main concern rather than pregnancy-related itching without a rash?

A widespread rash belongs in the Rash or Redness - Widespread pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is there reduced or changed fetal movement, heavy vaginal bleeding, severe breathing difficulty, collapse, or another immediate threat to the pregnant patient or baby?

HMC directs patients with concern about the baby's health or significant pregnancy red flags to an appropriate maternity emergency department and directs life-threatening emergencies to Qatar 999.

1. Disposition level 70

In this confirmed pregnancy, is there new or persistent itching, especially without a rash, on the palms or soles, worse at night, severe or generalized, or associated with yellowing of the skin or eyes?

RCOG states that itching can be the first sign of intrahepatic cholestasis of pregnancy and should be reported to a healthcare professional. Itching without rash, including palms or soles and worse at night, is characteristic; diagnosis requires clinical assessment and bile-acid/liver-function testing.

1. Disposition level 15

Has a maternity clinician already assessed this same mild, localized itching, found no concerning cause, provided a follow-up plan, and are there no new or worsening features?

NHS.UK guidance describes practical comfort measures for mild pregnancy-related itching once serious causes have been checked.

Advice

Emergency pregnancy warning signs

- For a life-threatening emergency, call Qatar 999. For reduced or changed fetal movement or significant pregnancy bleeding without immediate life threat, go immediately to the emergency department at the patient's booked HMC maternity hospital or the Qatar maternity destination approved for this UAT environment. Do not drive if faint, severely unwell, or bleeding heavily. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: fetal movement reduces further; bleeding, collapse, or breathing difficulty.

Prompt pregnancy itching review

- Arrange prompt maternity assessment through the patient's booked maternity service or the Qatar pathway approved for this UAT environment. Possible cholestasis cannot be confirmed by telephone and may require bile-acid and liver-function blood tests. Do not start an antihistamine or other medicine unless a maternity clinician or pharmacist confirms it is appropriate in this pregnancy.
- Call Back If: itching worsens or affects sleep; yellowing develops; fetal movement changes.

Comfort measures after maternity assessment

- Follow the maternity clinician's review plan. Cool compresses, lukewarm baths, unperfumed moisturizer, and loose cotton clothing may provide comfort. These measures do not treat cholestasis. Seek reassessment if itching persists, returns, or worsens; repeated blood tests may be needed when symptoms continue.
- Call Back If: itching becomes severe or affects sleep; yellowing or changed fetal movement develops.

First aid

- For a life-threatening emergency, call Qatar 999. For reduced or changed fetal movement or significant pregnancy bleeding without immediate life threat, go immediately to the emergency department at the patient's booked HMC maternity hospital or the Qatar maternity destination approved for this UAT environment. Do not drive if faint, severely unwell, or bleeding heavily. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- Royal College of Obstetricians and Gynaecologists, "Intrahepatic cholestasis of pregnancy", updated April 2026, <https://www.rcog.org.uk/for-the-public/browse-our-patient-information/intrahepatic-cholestasis-of-pregnancy/>
- Hamad Medical Corporation, "Maternity Care", <https://hamad.qa/EN/Hospitals-and-services/WWRC/Our-Services/Pages/Maternity-Care.aspx> (accessed 25 July 2026)
- World Health Organization, "Assessing and supporting adolescents' capacity for autonomous decision-making in health care settings", 2021

Provenance

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